



Apple's signature stitched leather texture.

For a Few Pixels More

But before we go forth and denounce skeuomorphism altogether, it is necessary to nitpick. The truth is that the kind of design we tend to associate with the term “skeuomorphism” isn’t all skeuomorphic. Therefore, it is necessary to clearly demarcate what is and isn’t skeuomorphic. The Oxford dictionary defines a skeuomorph as “an object or feature which

imitates the design of a similar artefact made from another material”. Which is to say that physical characteristics of a skeuomorph are the vestigial descendants of an original functionality; that have been retained purely for ornamental purposes. The said ornamental purposes are what we call “visual metaphor”.

Let us take up the example of the calculator application again. The on screen buttons of the calculator application are purely ornamental. They have been derived from the buttons on “real” calculators, but they share none of the hardware functionalities of the original. To compare, let us take up the stitched leather texture on the login page of the “Find My Friends”



Apple's calculator app.